

Rendering Workflow Guide

Backyard Fence Line Landscape Plan

May 2026

Rendering Workflow

Three workflows, ranked by output quality. Pick the one that matches your time budget and tool comfort.

Path	Time	Quality	Tool cost
A. D5 Render (primary, from SketchUp)	2-4 hrs	Photoreal	Free tier OK
B. SketchUp + Enscape (alternative)	2-3 hrs	Photoreal, real-time	\$39/mo
C. Reimagine Home AI (skip SketchUp)	15-30 min	Stylized, less precise	\$15/mo

Read all three first. Most people end up doing **A** for the master rendering and **C** for fast variations.

PATH A — SketchUp + D5 Render (recommended)

Step 1 — Prepare the SketchUp file

After running `landscape_plan.rb`:

1. **Turn off the Annotations layer** (Window → Default Tray → Tags → uncheck `06_Annotations`). Dimensions don't belong in a rendering.
2. **Save the file** as `landscape_plan.skp`.
3. (Optional but recommended) **Replace the stylized plant blocks with proper SketchUp Components** — see Step 2.

Step 2 — Swap stylized plants for realistic components

The Ruby script gives you correctly-positioned **placeholder geometry**. For a photoreal render you'll want real plant models in those exact positions.

Source of components: - **3D Warehouse** (built into SketchUp: Window → 3D Warehouse). Search: - "Karl Foerster" or "feather reed grass" — pick a model under 2MB - "echinacea purpurea" or "coneflower" (or "rudbeckia goldsturm") - **D5 Asset Library** (inside D5, after install) — has dozens of grasses and perennials, higher quality than 3DW, free with the app

Swap procedure (manual but fast):

1. Download one good Karl Foerster component into your model.
2. Right-click one of the existing stylized grass groups → **Replace Selected...** or just:
 - Select all groups named “Karl Foerster Grass” using Edit → Select All with same Name (or use Outliner)
 - Delete them
 - Use the **Make Component + Copy Array** approach: place the realistic component at each X,Y coordinate from the spec
3. Easier: skip this step. D5 has an in-app **“Scatter”** and **“Replace”** tool that swaps geometry at render time — see Step 4.

Pragmatic shortcut: The stylized markers from the Ruby script are at the exact correct positions. You can render them as-is in D5 and use D5’s **Object Replace** feature to swap them for D5 library plants without editing the .skp file.

Step 3 — Install D5 Render

- Download from d5render.com (Windows only — Mac users see Path B)
- Install the **D5 Converter for SketchUp** plugin during setup
- D5 has a free tier — fine for a few interior/exterior shots

Step 4 — Send model from SketchUp to D5

1. In SketchUp: **Extensions → D5 Converter → Sync to D5**
2. D5 opens with your geometry already imported and materials roughly mapped.

Step 5 — Apply materials in D5

- **Lawn:** D5 Library → Vegetation → Lawn Grass (any “Bermuda” or “Fescue” preset)
- **Mulch:** D5 Library → Ground → Bark Mulch / Hardwood Mulch
- **Fence:** D5 Library → Wood → Weathered Cedar or Aged Pine
- **Plants:** Select each stylized group → right-click → **Replace with Asset** → pick the realistic library version

Step 6 — Scatter additional plants (optional realism)

If the bed looks sparse, use **D5 Scatter** to add filler: - Low groundcover (creeping thyme, low sedum) between the spec’d plants - Mulch texture variation

Don’t overdo it — your spec is intentionally clean and linear.

Step 7 — Set up the camera

Reproduce the angle of your reference photo (Image 1 — the dome view):

- **Camera height:** 5’6” (eye level, standing on the lawn)
- **Camera position:** Stand on the lawn ~15 ft back from the bed, slightly to the left so you see the step
- **Focal length:** 35mm equivalent (D5 default is usually 50mm — change to 35 for the wider yard feel)
- Save as **Camera 1: Hero Shot**

Add 2–3 more cameras: - **Camera 2: Top-down plan view** (orthographic, looking straight down) - **Camera 3: Walking the bed** (3 ft off the fence, eye level, looking down the row) - **Camera 4: Year 3 mature** (same as Camera 1 but with plants scaled 110%)

Step 8 — Lighting

Use D5's **Sun & Sky**: - **Time of day**: 4:30 PM (warm side-light, long shadows — most flattering for grasses) - **Date**: July 15 (peak bloom for both Echinacea and Goldsturm) - **Cloud cover**: 20–30% (avoid blown-out skies) - **Sun direction**: Approximate your real yard orientation. If the fence runs east-west, sun should come from south. Eyeball it.

Step 9 — Render settings

For a final image (not a draft): - **Resolution**: 3840×2160 (4K) for hero, 1920×1080 for variations - **Quality**: “High” or “Ultra” - **Render time per frame**: 30 sec to 2 min on a decent GPU

Step 10 — Export

- PNG for sharing
 - Optionally render a **before/after pair** by hiding the bed/plants for the “before”
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PATH B — SketchUp + Enscape (Mac alternative)

D5 is Windows-only. If you're on Mac, use **Enscape** (now SketchUp-native, \$39/mo).

Differences from D5: - Real-time render preview (no render-button wait) - Smaller built-in asset library — supplement with [Quixel Bridge](#) free assets - Mac native, works fine on Apple Silicon - Steps 1–4 are the same; replace D5 steps 5–10 with Enscape's equivalent menus

Workflow: 1. Run the Ruby script in SketchUp 2. Open Enscape (Extensions → Enscape → Start Enscape) 3. Real-time view opens; navigate to your hero angle 4. Right-click stylized plants → Replace from Enscape Library 5. Adjust sun position, time of day in Enscape's sky panel 6. Click “Capture Image”

PATH C — Reimagine Home AI (skip SketchUp entirely)

If you want a fast preview before committing to SketchUp/D5, feed your **original yard photos** (the ones you uploaded) directly into an AI redesign tool.

Tool: reimaginehome.ai

1. Upload your hero photo (Image 1, the dome view).
2. Choose mode: “**Replace specific area**” or “**Garden / Backyard makeover**”.
3. Mask the strip of grass along the fence (the future bed area) using their brush tool.
4. Prompt:

“A 30-inch deep planting bed along the wood fence. Back row: Karl Foerster feather reed grass, 4-foot tall upright ornamental grass with vertical green blades and tan plumes, spaced 32 inches apart, 6 inches off the fence. Front row: purple coneflowers (*Echinacea purpurea*) with pink-purple daisy

blooms, 14 inches apart. Shredded hardwood mulch ground cover. Late summer, peak bloom, golden hour light, photorealistic.”

5. Generate 4 variations. Pick the best.
6. Re-prompt with **the same image + tweaks** (“more density,” “shorter flowers,” “swap to yellow black-eyed Susans”) to iterate.

Pros vs. SketchUp path

- 15 minutes vs. 3 hours
- No software install
- Easy to test Coneflower vs. Goldsturm side by side

Cons

- Plant counts and spacing are **suggestive, not precise** — the AI won’t honor your exact 17/36 spec
- Fence step may get distorted
- Same view only; hard to get the top-down plan or a year-3 mature view
- Bed edge may not be straight

Best use: Show this to anyone who needs to *feel* what the finished bed will look like, while you use Path A for the precise install drawing.

RECOMMENDED PIPELINE

Here’s the order of operations if you want a complete deliverable package:

1. **Run the Ruby script in SketchUp** → exact installation diagram with verified spacing
2. **Export 2 SketchUp views** as PNG:
 - Top-down plan view (turn ON 06_Annotations layer, switch to Parallel Projection + Top view)
 - 3D perspective from the dome angle
3. **Use Path C (Reimagine Home)** on your original photo for a “vibe” rendering — fast, photorealistic, shows neighbors what’s coming
4. **Use Path A (D5 Render)** if you want the precise photoreal hero image with correct plant positions

The combo of (1) + (3) covers 90% of real use cases (planning + visualization). Add (4) only if you want gallery-quality output for a presentation or contractor review.

SAVE FILES TO KEEP

File	Purpose
landscape_plan.rb	Source of truth — re-run any time
landscape_plan.skp	Editable spec drawing
landscape_plan_top.png	Plan-view export (for contractor / printing)
landscape_plan_3d.png	Perspective export
landscape_hero.png	Final D5 or Reimagine render
landscape_plan.pdf	Written plan document

TROUBLESHOOTING

Ruby script ran but I see nothing - Press **Shift+Z** (Zoom Extents) - Check the Ruby Console for an error message - Verify SketchUp version is 2017 or later

Plants are floating above the ground - The script places plants at Z=0. If your ground plane is at a different Z, select all groups and use Move to drop them.

D5 Converter doesn't appear in Extensions menu - Reinstall D5 with SketchUp closed first - Manual install: copy the .rbz from D5's install folder to ~/Library/Application Support/SketchUp [version]/SketchUp/Plugins/

Reimagine Home keeps changing the fence - Mask MORE tightly around just the grass strip - Add to prompt: "Keep existing wood fence exactly as in source image, only modify the strip of grass in front of the fence."

AI render shows wrong plant counts - This is expected — AI tools don't count. Use it for vibe, use the Ruby script + SketchUp for spec.

FINAL NOTE

The most common mistake at this stage is **over-investing in the rendering**. Your contractor (or you) installs from the **plan document + the top-down SketchUp view**, not from the pretty render. The render exists to convince yourself and your spouse/neighbor/HOA that the design works. Make it good enough to communicate the idea, then go buy plants.